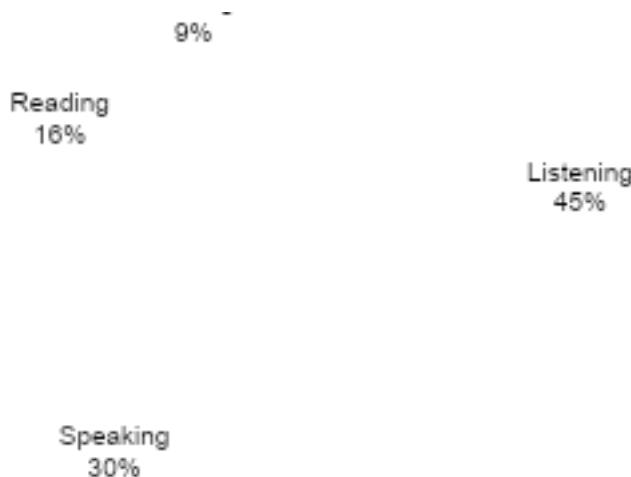


GANPAT UNIVERSITY
Faculty of Computer Applications
BCA Semester – I
Communication Skills

Unit : 3 - Receptive Language Skills (Listening & Reading)

(A) Listening Comprehension

- Listening is one of the important skills for students as well as to professionals.
- Listening and Reading are receptive skills and they together claim 61% of the professionals' time.



(Allocation of time by professionals on different Communication Skills)

- Students have to listen to a great variety of oral content in the following situations:
- Lectures (classroom), explanations of experiments (laboratories), instructions and advices (library/student section/welfare centre/health centre), suggestions (teachers), presentations (seminar/conference/workshop), speeches (formal functions), questions (interview).
- Professionals (engineers) have to listen to different types of oral messages in different situations.
- Conversations (in and outside organization), instructions (from superiors), explanations and suggestions (from sub-ordinates), answers (from candidates during interviews), presentations (seminar/conference/workshop), information and knowledge (from media).
- By listening to the sub-ordinates, superiors, outsiders, media, other organizations, private and government agencies, they collect information. This information is processed by them and this is how they make decisions and frame/modify policies.
- According to Tom Peter, “Listening is one of the most important leadership and management skills.”

Definition of Listening:

“Listening is a process of receiving, interpreting, evaluating and responding to the oral messages”. OR

“Listening is a process of receiving, interpreting and reacting to a message received from the speaker.”

- Tom Peters says, “Listening is one of the most essential management and leadership skill.”
- Listening is an art of making sense out of spoken words.

Listening Vs Hearing:

- Listening is voluntary while hearing is involuntary.
- Listening is a deliberate activity while hearing is natural.
- Listening requires proper attention and interpretation while hearing does not require them.
- Listening is a systematic process while hearing is random and haphazard.
- In listening stimulus-response occurs while in hearing it does not.

Process of Listening:

- Listening is a process of receiving and interpreting the spoken words. It involves recognizing what is said and comprehending the matter, i.e. understanding the main and subsidiary points as well as the link between different parts of speech.
- It is quite similar to reading as it involves reception and decoding of verbal messages from the other person. It is not enough to depend only on receiving the message. Serious efforts should be made not only to receive the messages but also to interpret them correctly.
- While receiving and interpreting the spoken words, the listener is concerned with the four factors i.e. sensing, message decoding or interpreting, evaluating and response.

Sensing:

Listening begins with physical hearing of the message. It is known as sensing, which is the first step of listening process. We hear sounds and concentrate on them in order to receive the message. Once we are able to recognize the sound pattern, we decode and interpret the message.

Decoding:

Decoding or interpreting in listening refers to the process of changing the coded message into information. It involves understanding the spoken language. Interpretation of a verbal message may be influenced by our social, educational, cultural, professional and intellectual frames of reference.

Evaluating:

After the message has been decoded and understood, its significance is evaluated and appropriate conclusions are drawn from it. In order to evaluate a verbal message correctly, facts have to be separated from opinions, relevant information from irrelevant one, examples from ideas and explicit information from implicit one. The intention and attitude of the speaker has also to be analysed.

Response:

Response is the action or reaction of the listener to the message. It is the last stage of listening process. If the message has been analysed, interpreted and evaluated correctly, the response will be appropriate. The response makes the communication complete and effective as it clarifies the message and helps the speakers to know whether the message has been understood or not.

Causes of poor listening:**1. Unavailability of formal training**

Formal training is available for Speaking, Reading and Writing but, no such training is available for listening.

2. Discrepancy in speed of thought and speed of speech

The speed of thought is around 500 words per minute but, the speed of speech is around 125 words per minute. The mind wanders in the free time.

3. Inborn poor listeners

We, as human beings, believe that our listening skill is quite alright and this is why we do not make any extra efforts for its further development.

Traits of a good listener:**1. Being non-evaluative**

An attentive listener should listen to the content of speaker carefully and the speech should be evaluated only after it is completely over.

2. Paraphrasing

To clarify a point, one can simply paraphrase what the speaker has said and enquire from the speaker whether one has heard it accurately. Do this by summarizing what they've said. Use below mentioned phrases:

“So do you mean to say that?”

“If I've heard you right, what you're saying is that...”

“So what you are saying is...”

“As I gather, you want to say that...”

3. Reflecting implications

To reflect on the implications of the spoken words, you have to think beyond the direct words of the speaker, appreciating his/her ideas and understanding where those ideas are leading to. This may encourage the speaker to further extend the ideas. By doing this, listener is trying to reflect eagerness and zest by verbal and non-verbal means, thereby giving positive feedback.

The listener tries to cultivate a desire to truly understand from the speaker's point of view by listening to the speaker and looking for clues. Below mentioned phrases can be used:

“So this might lead to the result which...”

“I’m sure if we did that, we would be in a position to...”

“So you are suggesting that we...”

“Could it possibly imply that...?”

4. Reflecting hidden feelings

Sometimes, as a good listener one must try to go beyond the spoken words to unravel (know) the hidden feelings influencing the speaker’s words. Good listeners must try and empathize or identify themselves with the speaker, to experience what they feel by using phrases like:

"That must have been difficult."

"Sounds like you've had a really bad time."

“If I were you, I would not have handled the situation so well.”

“That must have been a satisfying experience.”

But don’t try to say too much or solve their problems by over exposing the speaker and coaxing the speaker to admit more than they desire. Sometimes just listening or even just being there with them is enough.

5. Inviting further contribution

It is amazing what people will say when they are encouraged to speak, and you may be surprised at what you learn. In a situation where we have not heard or understood enough yet to show our interest and empathy, we must prompt the speaker to give more information. Phrases such as the following can be used:

“Can you throw more light on...”

“It would be great if you could explain more on the topic.”

“What happened after that?”

“How did you react when...?”

While it is useful to ask questions, one must guard against asking too many. This may lead speakers to suspect that rather than seeking information, the listener is interrogating or challenging them.

Always try to ask Open-ended questions. For instance, ‘What solutions have you thought of?’ ‘How do you feel about’ ...?, ‘What's happening now?’ etc. are Open-ended questions whereas ‘Have you thought of any solution?’ is a close-ended question. Open-ended questions create a more supportive and trusting climate.

6. Responding non-verbally

The way you sit or stand can encourage someone to feel relaxed around you, and that you want to hear what they have to say. Be relaxed but show you are concentrating on what is being said.

For example, relax your arms don't cross them. Sitting slightly forward, and tilting your head means you are listening. Maintain proper eye contact but don't start staring. Give occasional smiles and nods where appropriate. Show that you are interested by nodding and using short words - "Ahmm" "yes" "I see" "Go on".

Sit up, look interested, Lean forward, Listen, Act interested, Nod your head to show that you are tuned in, track the speaker with your eyes.

Modes of Listening:

Active Mode of Listening (Reflective Listening):

In active or reflective listening, we are genuinely interested in understanding what the speaker is speaking and what the message means. In this mode, we receive, decode, interpret and evaluate the message and simultaneously we update our understanding/verify our comprehension/provide suggestions or appreciate the speaker by verbal interaction with the speaker (response). Active listening is known to be reflective because that listening stirs your thinking and compels you to participate in the conversation. This mode is similar to throwing torch-light on mirror which reflects back.

For example: Judges of a Music concert listen to the singer using this mode.

Passive Mode of Listening (Attentive Listening):

In passive listening, the listener listens to the speaker with full attention but, the subsequent processes discussed above do not happen simultaneously. The listener listens, decodes and interprets but, do not reflect on the thoughts received. It is similar to throwing torch light on wall or anything that is opaque.

For example: Audience of a Music concert listen to the singer in this mode.

Competitive Mode of Listening (Combative Listening):

In this mode, the focus is on the arguments and information which is being presented and the listener looks for every opportunity to cut short (interrupt) the speaker and object to the arguments and information presented by the speaker.

For example: Participants of debate listen to their opponents in this mode.

(B) Reading Comprehension

- Reading is a very important and useful skill that one should pay serious attention to and should develop fully.
- Students have to read a great variety of texts as shown below during their student life.
- Text books, reference books, research articles from of journals, lectures notes, handout and pamphlets on subject topics, newspapers, magazines, books of general knowledge, books on competitive exam subjects etc.
- Professionals (engineers) also have to read a variety of texts as discussed below.

- Newspapers, newsletters, press release, magazines, journals, different types of reports published by different private and government agencies etc.

Definition of reading:

“Reading is a process of receiving, interpreting, evaluating and responding to the written messages”.

Purposes of reading:

- To get new information
- To update the existing information
- To learn about what is going in the external world.

Suggestion for developing sharp reading skills:

- Read longer texts.
- Read variety of texts.
- Know the meanings of unfamiliar words.
- Recall and try to retain what is read.
- Read with concentration and interest.

Techniques (strategies) for Effective reading comprehension:

1. Skimming and Scanning

- Skimming means reading with eyes without lip movement.
- Skim the text and try to get information about three important aspects:
 1. For which audience the text is written (general public, professionals, laymen...)
 2. What type of text it is (report, informal letter, article, advertisement...)
 3. What the purpose of the author is (to describe, to inform, to explain, to instruct, to persuade).
- Scanning refers to skimming the text with objective of locating some specific information.

2. Non-verbal signals

- The meaning of the text is not only conveyed by words. All texts also contain non-verbal signals: style signals and lay-out signals.
- Style signals include features such as different fonts, bold print, underlining or italics.
- Layout signals include title, heading, subheading, photographs, caption, figures, graphs, charts etc.

3. Structure of the text

- Most texts contain three parts: introduction, body and conclusion.
- An important aspect of reading is prediction. The better you can predict what you are going to read, the faster and more effective you will read. The prediction process begins with the title.

- The introduction mostly informs you about what you can expect. The body consists of paragraphs. Each paragraph deals with one aspect of the subject matter. The logical linking of sentences within a paragraph is called coherence. Logical link between paragraphs is called cohesion. The conclusion sums up and puts the subject matter in the right perspective.

4. **Structure of the paragraphs**

- A typical paragraph consists of two parts. The main sentence of the paragraph is called topic sentence, which is the heart of the paragraph. The topic sentence is also called thesis sentence or key sentence around which the discussion revolves. The second part of the paragraph contains sub-coordinating sentences which develop the topic sentence. These sentences may contain arguments, explanations, details, examples, and other supportive evidence.
- In many well written texts the reader will get a good impression of the content by just reading the first sentences (topic sentence) of each paragraph.

5. **Punctuation**

- A sensible reader is also expected to have fair understanding of different punctuation marks. Punctuation is partly based on grammar. For example, commas are often used to separate clauses. If you understand the meaning and usage of punctuation mark, it will be easier to understand the grammatical structure.
- Punctuation marks also indicate how the author wants you to interpret the piece of text. For example, if the author puts something in brackets, that part of the sentence should be interpreted as an addition to the sentence. Other punctuation marks are colon, semi-colon, dash, hyphen, quotation marks etc.

6. **Author's viewpoint (inference)**

- In reading a text one makes inferences or assumption about the position of the author. Is the author neutral or s/he has an opinion? The author often shows his or her opinion either by adding certain phrases or by adding a value to a word.
- The author can add words like luckily and unfortunately to show approval or disapproval. He can also add words which show his surprise, regret or other emotions – for example, surprisingly, unexpectedly, regrettably desirable, to be disappointed, to my utter dismay etc. The author may also use the words to indicate the level of certainty – for example certainly, obviously, undoubtedly, naturally, etc. The author could also add words to comment on more or less objective facts. For example: The sentence ‘Only 40% staff is female’ has different meaning than the sentence ‘As much as 40% of the staff is female.’
- The author can also reveal his view point by adding value to a word. For example, if something is big he may use the word ‘huge’ or ‘gigantic’ to indicate that he is impressed. If something is small

he may use words like ‘tiny’ or ‘microscopic’ to indicate that he is not so impressed. If someone is afraid he may use the word ‘terrified’. If something is good he may use the word ‘fantastic’.

7. **Reader anticipation: Determining the meaning of words**

- Even readers who have a wide and flexible vocabulary will encounter words whose meaning they do not know. This skill can be developed by the following the below given method.

Step 1: Determine the word class i.e., a verb, a noun, an adjective, an adverb, etc.

Step 2: Determine its function in the sentence i.e., how it is related to other words in the sentence.

Step 3: Analyze the contextual clue, i.e., the context in which we find this word positive or negative; what the context tells us about the word.

Step 4: Try and derive the eventual meaning of the word.

8. **Summarizing**

- It is very difficult to remember the complete contents of a long text. For that reason it is often advisable to make notes of essential information in the text. The result is a short outline of a text containing all its important aspects.
- An average summary would be almost one-third of the original text. But summaries of detailed texts may be longer. There are a few guidelines to summarize any text.
 - Familiarize yourself with the material
 - Select important information
 - Paraphrase the information
 - Insert links between sentences and paragraphs
 - Adjust the length
